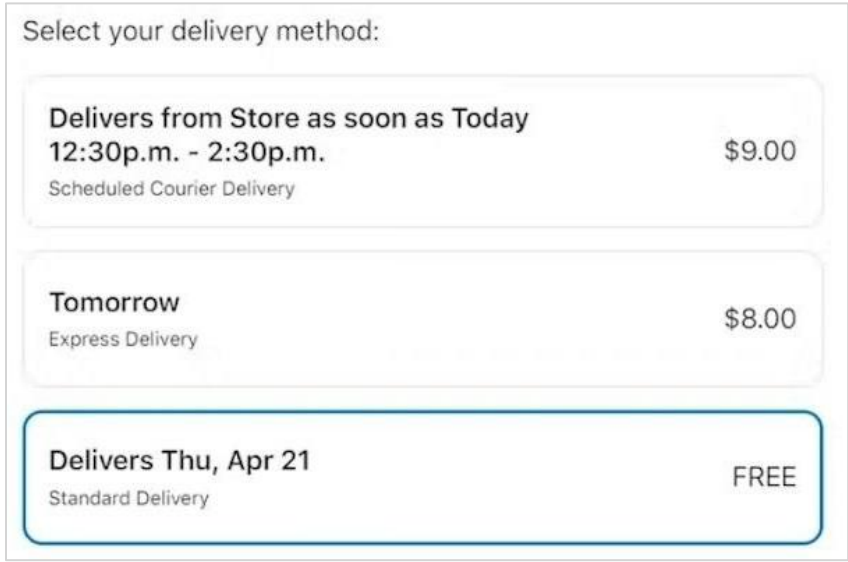
Why good UI feels good

and why AI slop doesn't





Zeki Erman · BİL 333 Mesleki Yabancı Dil-1 · 12 November 2026

Merriam-Webster, word of the year 2025

slop

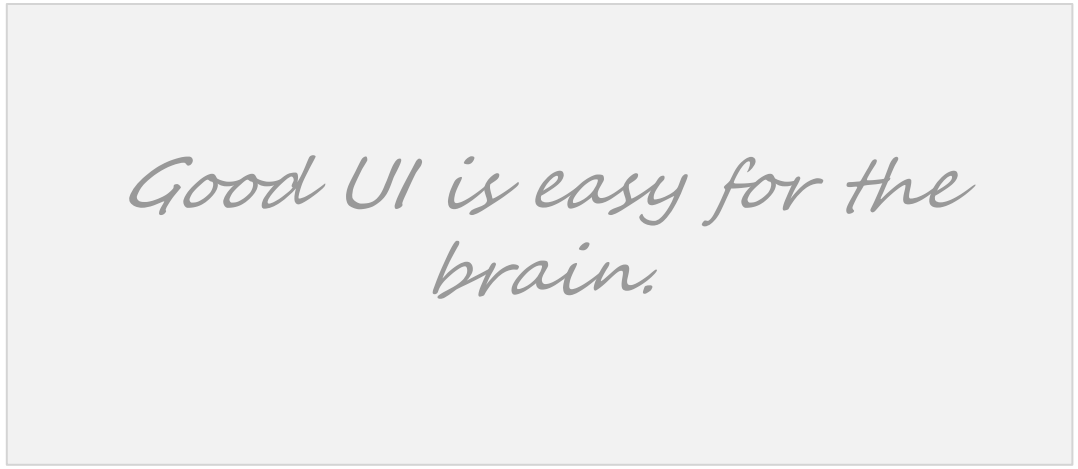
"digital content of low quality that is produced usually in quantity by means of artificial intelligence"

I can spot it in a second. Why?

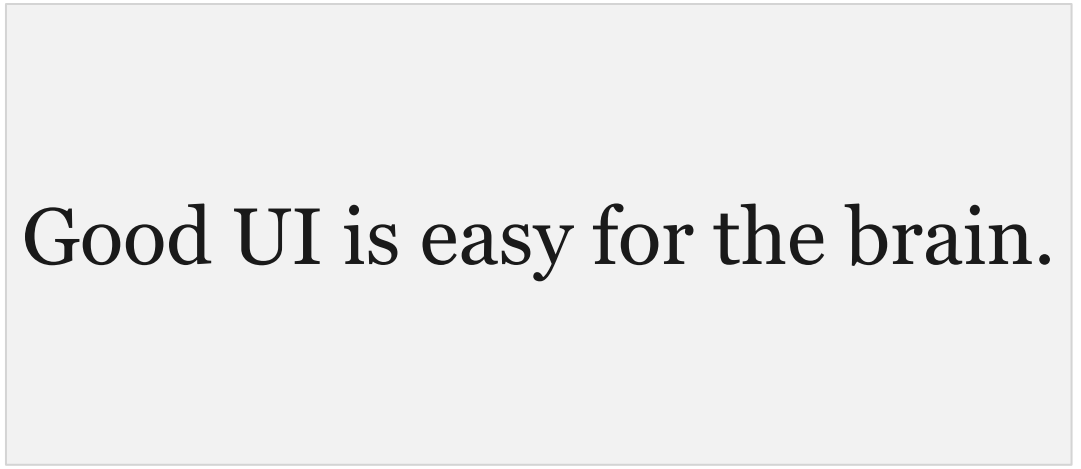


AI-made ad for "Willy's Chocolate Experience", Glasgow 2024. Read the words. Image: Wikipedia, "AI slop"

The brain likes easy



harder to read



easy to read

Processing fluency: when something is easy for the brain, it feels good. We like it more.

Reber, Schwarz & Winkielman (2004), Personality and Social Psychology Review

My main idea

Bad UI makes your brain ask questions.

Good UI answers them before you ask.

Every question is a little bit of work. Less work for your brain feels good.

On the next slides: first, you have to guess. Then, you just know.

Nielsen Norman Group: "Minimize cognitive load" (2013), "Few guesses, more success" (2025)

When will it arrive?

You have to guess *Snowe: "Typically 4-7 business days"*



You just know *Apple: "Delivers Thu, Apr 21"*



Screens: Baymard Institute, Current state of checkout UX, 2026

What is wrong?

You have to guess *GameStop: "Phone number is required"*



You just know *Away: "Your card number is incomplete."*



Screens: Baymard Institute, Adaptive validation error messages, 2023

Is my size there?

You have to guess *Adidas: sizes hidden in a menu*



You just know *Under Armour: all sizes on the screen, sold out in grey*



Screens: Baymard Institute, Always use buttons for size selection, 2021

What do these icons do?

You have to guess *Linear 2026: icons only*

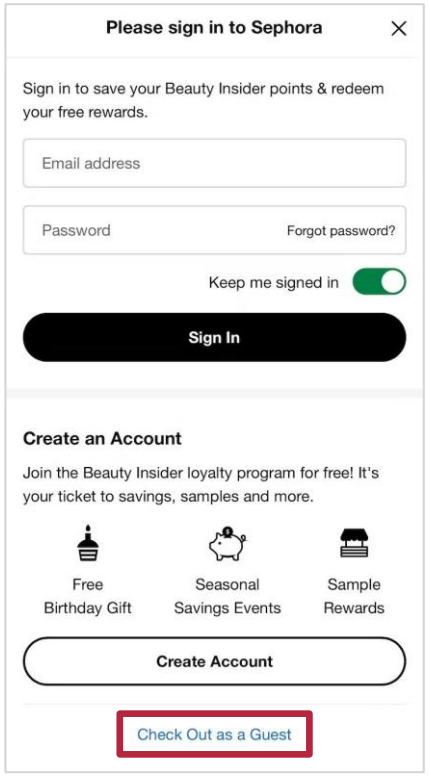


You just know *Linear before 2026: icon + word*



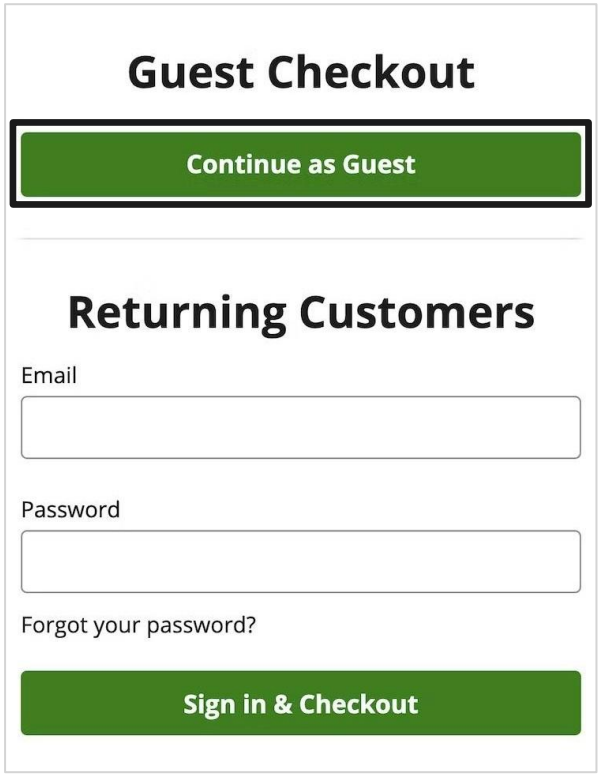
Screens: Linear, A calmer interface for a product in motion, 2026

Do I need an account?



You have to guess

Sephora: a small link at the very bottom

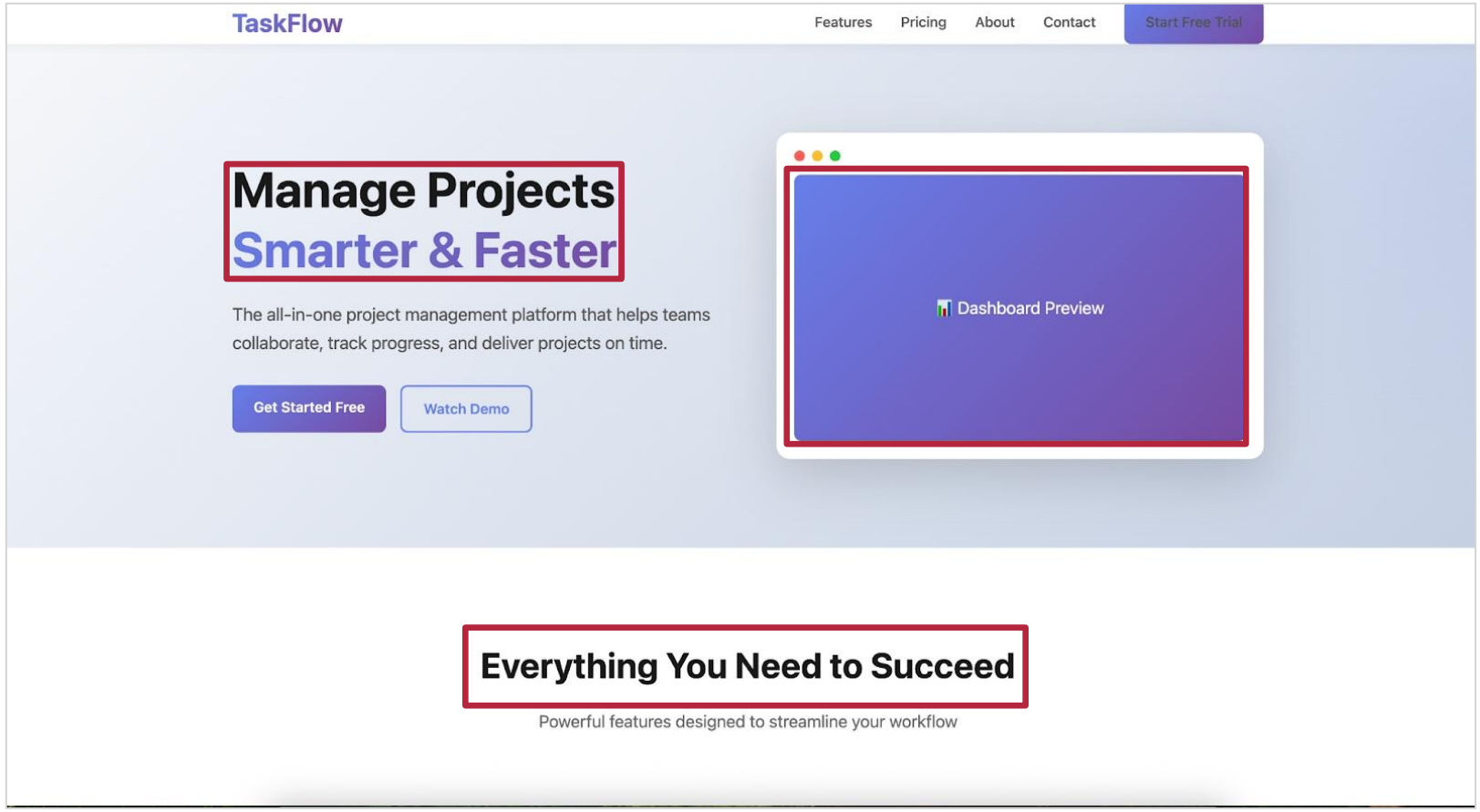


You just know

Bass Pro Shops: "Continue as Guest" first

Screens: Baymard Institute, Make guest checkout the most prominent option, 2023

Now look at AI slop



AI-made page, no design rules given. Image: Anthropic, 2025

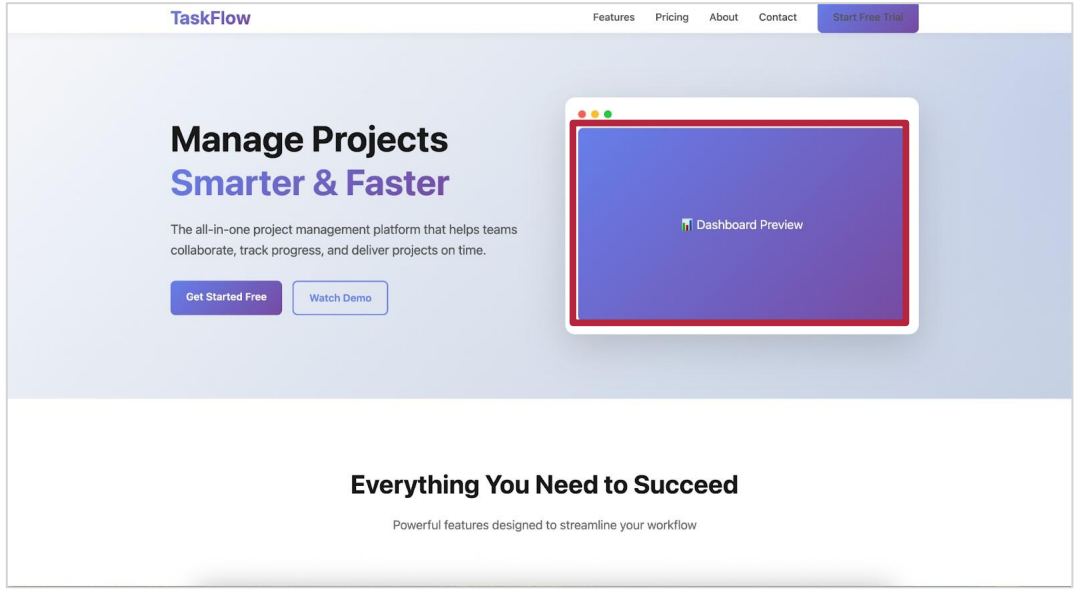
"Smarter & Faster" than what?

Dashboard Preview: where is the dashboard?

Everything I need: for what?

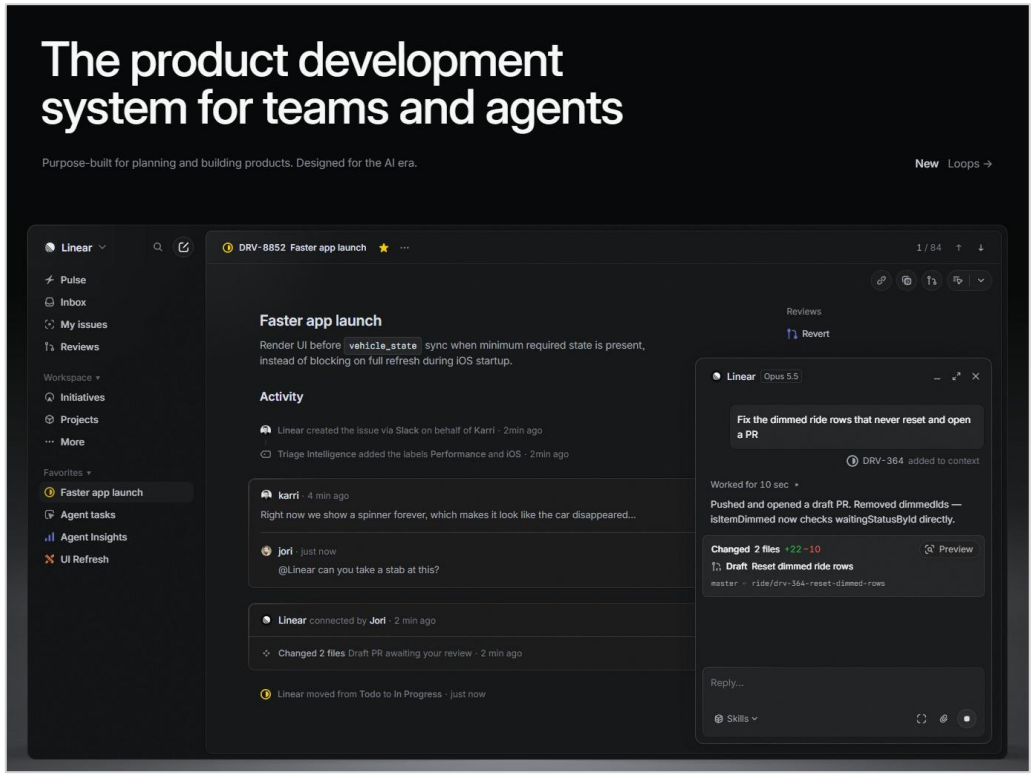
The page doesn't answer.

What does the product look like?



A purple box

AI-made page (Anthropic, 2025)



The real app

linear.app home page (screenshot, 7 November 2026)

To sum up

When will it arrive?



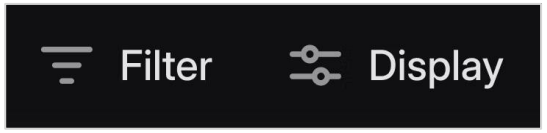
What is wrong?



Is my size there?



What does this do?



Good UI answers your brain's questions before you ask them.

AI slop looks familiar, but it leaves the questions open.

Thank you! Any questions?

Sources

1. Reber, R., Schwarz, N., & Winkielman, P. (2004). Processing fluency and aesthetic pleasure: Is beauty in the perceiver's processing experience? Personality and Social Psychology Review, 8(4), 364-382.
2. Whitenton, K. (2013). Minimize cognitive load to maximize usability. Nielsen Norman Group. nngroup.com/articles/minimize-cognitive-load
3. Wang, H. (2025, July 18). Few guesses, more success: 4 principles to reduce cognitive load in forms. Nielsen Norman Group. nngroup.com/articles/4-principles-reduce-cognitive-load
4. Baymard Institute. Current state of checkout UX (2026); Adaptive validation error messages (2023); Always use buttons for size selection (2021); Make guest checkout prominent (2023). baymard.com/research-articles
5. Linear (2026, March 12). A calmer interface for a product in motion. linear.app/now
6. Anthropic (2025, November 12). Improving frontend design through Skills. claude.com/resources/articles
7. Merriam-Webster (2025). Word of the Year 2025: Slop. merriam-webster.com/wordplay/word-of-the-year
8. Images: Baymard Institute research screenshots; linear.app; Anthropic; Willy's Chocolate Experience ad from Wikipedia's "AI slop" article (public domain).